

Genesis 6-9

8:1: The Pivot: God Remembers Noah

- God causes a wind to blow upon the waters

8:2-5: The Flood Recedes from the Land

- The waters above and below are restrained
- The ark rests upon the mountains

8:6-14: Noah Sends out Birds to See if the Waters Have Dried Up

- Noah sends out the raven (impure)
- Noah sends out the dove 3 times (pure)
- Noah removes the cover and sees the dry land

8:15-19: Divine Speech: Noah to Leave the Ark

- Divine command: Noah, his family, and animals to go out from the ark
- Fulfillment: Noah, his family, and animals all go out from the ark

8:20-22: Noah's Sacrifice Deals With the Earthly Rebellion

- Noah builds an altar and offers a sacrifice
- Yahweh speaks to his heart
- The heart of humanity is bad
- But never again will Yahweh curse or strike the land

9:1-7: Divine Speech: Blessing and Provision of Food

- God blesses Noah: Be fruitful and multiply
- Animals are food for humanity
- No eating the blood, no bloodshed among humans

9:8-17: Divine Speech: The Covenant for the Preservation of Life

- God's covenant with Noah, all humanity, and all living creatures
- Never again ruin the earth by flood
- Sign of the covenant: rainbow in the cloud

9:18-27: The Rebellion of Ham and Noah's Blessing and Curse

- Ham "sees the nakedness of his father" = illicit sex
- Shem and Japheth cover and do not see the nakedness
- Ham is cursed, Shem and Japheth are blessed

Macrodesign of the Flood Story Expanded. Adapted from Teeter, Andrew (2019). "Genesis Class Notes." By BibleProject for Classroom: Noah to Abraham (2020).

The Flood Narrative in Ancient Near Eastern Context

In 1847, Austin Henry Layard discovered near Mosul the first of thousands of cuneiform tablets that belonged to the library of Ashurbanipal (King of Assyria, 7th century B.C.E.).

In 1872, George Smith presented his careful work of bringing together many tablets called the Epic of Gilgamesh ("The Chaldean Account of the Deluge").

"A short time back I discovered among the Assyrian tablets in the British museum an account of the flood ... I had divided the collection of tablets into sections according to subject matter. I have recently been examining the division comprising the mythological tablets and from this section there was a copy of the story of the flood. On discovering these documents, I searched all over the collection of fragments, consisting of several thousand pieces, and I recovered 80 fragments of these legends; by the aid of which I was enabled to restore nearly all of the text of the description of the flood, and portions of other legends as well ... Of the inscription describing the flood, there are fragments of three copies containing the same texts ... All these accounts, together with considerable portions of other mythologies, have, I believe, a common origin in the plains of Chaldea. This country, the cradle of civilization, the birthplace of the arts and sciences, for 2,000 years has been in ruins; its literature, containing the most precious records from antiquity, is scarcely known to us, except from the texts of the Assyrians, but beneath mounds and ruined cities, now awaiting exploration, lay, together with older copies of the flood, other legends and histories of the earliest civilizations of the world."

Smith, George (1873). [*The Chaldean Account of the Deluge*](#) (2). Transactions of the Society of Biblical Archaeology. 213-34.

Hermann Gunkel's *Creation and Chaos in the Beginning and the End* claimed that Genesis 1-11 displayed extensive dependence upon Babylonian traditions.

- Creation from battles with the chaos-water dragon
- Creation of humans from the dust
- Ancient king lists: pre-flood kings living for thousands of years
- Flood stories

In the 20th century, older versions of this Mesopotamian flood story were discovered, bringing it to a total of five separate versions in four languages.

- 16th century B.C.E. Sumerian-Babylonian version: Eridu Genesis
- 17th century B.C.E. Akkadian version: Epic of Atrahasis
- 13th century B.C.E. Akkadian version in the Epic of Gilgamesh
- The biblical version, dated anywhere from the 12th-6th century B.C.E.
- 3rd century B.C.E. Greek version preserved in the writings of the Babylonian priest Berossus

These versions are all descendants of a common ancestor, as they share a unique list of similarities in detail. In all of these stories, we see the following similarities and differences.

The Common Framework Between All Three Accounts

- A divine decision is made to send a punishing flood
- One chosen man is told to save himself, his family, and creatures by building a boat

- The boat's proportions and design imitate a sacred temple
- A great flood destroys the rest of the people
- The boat runs aground on a mountain
- Birds are sent out to determine the availability of habitable land
- The hero offers a sacrifice to the gods
- Humanity is renewed on the land

Tsumura, David Toshio (1994). "Genesis and Ancient Near Eastern Stories of Creation and Flood." *I Studied Inscriptions from Before the Flood: Ancient Near Eastern, Literary, and Linguistic Approaches to Genesis 1-11*. Eisenbrauns. 54-55.

Similarities Between Genesis and Tablet 11 of the Gilgamesh Epic

Narrative Motif	Genesis Flood Story	Gilgamesh Epic, Tablet 11
Divine decision to destroy humanity	Gen. 6:6	Lines 14-19
Warning to the flood hero	Gen. 6:13	Lines 20-23
Divine command to build an ark with dimensions given	Gen. 6:14-21	Lines 24-31
Hero complies with the command	Gen. 6:22	Lines 32-85
Command to board the ark	Gen. 7:1-4	Lines 86-88
Hero boards the ark with family and animals	Gen. 7:5-16	Lines 89-93
Closing of the door of the ark	Gen. 7:16	Line 93
Description of the flood	Gen. 7:17-24	Lines 96-128
Destruction of life	Gen. 7:21-23	Lines 133
Conclusion of the storm	Gen. 8:1-3	Lines 129-131
Ark runs aground on a mountain	Gen. 8:4	Line 140-144
Adapted from Wenham, Gordon (1978). "The Coherence of the Flood Narrative." <i>Vetus Testamentum</i> , Volume 28 (July). 346-347.		

Narrative Motif	Genesis Flood Story	Gilgamesh Epic, Tablet 11
Hero opens a window	Gen. 8:6	Line 135
Sending out of the dove and raven	Gen. 8:6-12	Lines 145-154
Hero exits the ark	Gen. 8:15-19	Line 155
Hero offers a sacrifice	Gen. 8:20	Lines 155-158
Deity smells sacrifice	Gen. 8:21-22	Lines 159-161
Deity blesses flood hero	Gen. 9:1-3	Lines 189-196
Adapted from Wenham, Gordon (1978). "The Coherence of the Flood Narrative." <i>Vetus Testamentum</i> , Volume 28 (July). 346-347.		

Key Differences Between the Mesopotamian Accounts and Genesis

Mesopotamian Flood Stories	Genesis Flood Story
The gods grow tired of the noise and disorder of humanity, and make a rash decision (that some gods regret!) to destroy them with the flood	God hears the outcry that results from humanity's moral corruption and violence, and sees their inclination to ruin his world
The assembly of gods tries to conceal the flood plan from the humans	Absent
The chief god decrees total human destruction; only one hero is saved by a rebel deity who secretly informs him about the coming threat <i>Eridu Genesis: Ziusudra</i> <i>Atrahasis: Atrahasis</i> <i>Gilgamesh Epic: Uta-napishti</i>	God views Noah as the only faithful human and initiates in warning him and instructing for his safety
The duration of the flood is either 7 days (Atrahasis, Babylonian) or 6 days and nights	God offers 7 days' warning, followed by 40 days of storm, followed by 150 days of recession, followed
<i>Key Differences Between Flood Stories.</i> Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Noah to Abraham (2020).	

Mesopotamian Flood Stories	Genesis Flood Story
(Gilgamesh Epic).	by multiple stages of 7 days until the flood is over 1 year and 10 days from its beginning (Gen. 7:11; 8:14).
The scope of destruction varies in the accounts: • Atrahasis: total destruction is ordered by the gods • Gilgamesh: all people turn back into clay, though the tops of the mountains are still visible	All the high mountains were covered (Gen. 7:19-20), there was water over all the surface of the land.
The inhabitants of the boat include a pilot and craftsmen, and lots of animals	Noah and his family and pairs of animals
The gods are hungry after 7 days of no food, and swarm around the sacrifice	Noah's sacrifice is pleasing to God but not to satisfy divine hunger; rather it is an act of thanks
The gods establish a "sign": a female goddess dons a shiny blue necklace that reminds the gods to never bring the flood again	God establishes a sign of the covenant (rainbow) to remind humans of God's promise: the humans are obligated to not shed blood (Gen. 9:4-6)
The flood hero is given divine life and becomes a demi-god king (Ziusudra), or is invited to Mt. Dilmun, the eternal realm of the gods (Utnapishti)	Noah receives the new-humanity commission, but he immediately fails in his own garden
<i>Key Differences Between Flood Stories.</i> Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Noah to Abraham (2020).	

Gordon Wenham outlines three basic approaches to explaining these connections in *Word Biblical Commentary, Volume 1: Genesis 1-15* (Wenham, 1987).

1. Minimalists: The differences are too great to suppose direct dependence of the Genesis account on the Mesopotamian. Both are independent developments of an earlier common tradition.
2. Maximalists: The author of Genesis was familiar with and dependent upon Mesopotamian traditions in something like their present form. The writer is therefore deliberately opposing, subverting, or expanding on them.
3. Moderates: The truth lies somewhere between the minimalist and maximalist, depending on the specific motif or textual detail.

"Everyone in the ancient Near East knew there was a great flood (just like everyone today knows there was a Holocaust.) It is in the cultural river. The question was, what was God up to? Why did he send the flood? On this point, different texts offer vastly different interpretations, and every culture gave the tradition its own shape. The Mesopotamian accounts are drawing out of the cultural river and spinning it according to their

cultural ideas and theology. The biblical authors are doing the same. We need not concern ourselves with whether the Israelite authors had access to copies of the Mesopotamian accounts ... What is important is the difference in the interpretation of the event. Here there are noticeable differences between the ancient Near Eastern accounts, and the biblical account has a vastly different interpretation to offer."

Longman, Tremper and Walton, J. H. (2018). [*The Lost World of the Flood: Mythology, Theology, and the Deluge Debate*](#). IVP Academic. 62-63.

Flood Accounts From the Ancient Mesopotamian World

Gilgamesh Epic, Tablet 11

Language: Akkadian / Date: roughly 18th century B.C.E.

"Gilgamesh spoke to Utnapishtim ...

'Tell me, how is it that you stand in the assembly of the Gods, and have found life?'

Utnapishtim said to him, to Gilgamesh,

'Let me reveal to you, O Gilgamesh, a hidden matter,

And a secret of the gods let me tell you.

Shuruppak, a city you know of,

[And which on] Euphrates [bank] is situate,

That city was ancient and the gods were within it.

The great gods resolved to send the deluge.

They [sw]ore their father Anu,

Their counselor the warrior Enlil,

Their throne-bearer Ninurta,

Their canal-officer Ennugi,

The leader Ea was under oath with them.

He repeated their plans to the reed hut,

"Reed hut, reed hut, wall, wall!

Listen reed hut, be mindful, wall!

Man of Shuruppak, son of Ubartutu,

Destroy this house, build a ship,

Forsake possessions, seek life,

Build an ark and save life.

Take aboard ship seed of all living things.

The ship which you shall build,

Let her dimensions be measured off.

Let her width and length be equal,

Roof her over like a hidden depth."

I understood full well, I said to Ea my lord,

"[Your command], my lord, which you spoke just so,

I shall faithfully execute ..."

On the fifth day I laid her framework,

One full acre was her floor space,

Ten dozen cubits each was the height of her walls,
Ten dozen cubits each were the edges around her.
I laid out her contours, I sketched out her lines,
I decked her in six,
I divided her in seven,
Her interior I divided nine ways.
I drove the water plugs into her,
I saw to the spars and laid in what was needful.
Thrice 3,600 measures of pitch I poured in the oven,
Thrice 3,600 measures of tar did [I pour out] inside her.
Thrice 3,600 measures of oil for the workers who carried the baskets,
Aside from the 300 measures of oil that the caulking consumed,
And twice 3,600 measures of oil that the boatmen stored away.
For the [builders] bullocks were slaughtered,
And I killed sheep every day,
Fine beer, [grape] wine, oil and date wine,
[Did I give] the workers [to drink] like drinking water,
They made a feast as on New Year's Day.
[I opened (?)] ointment, dispensed [it] with my own hand.
On the seventh day (?) the ship was completed ...

What silver I had I loaded upon her,
What gold I had I loaded upon her,
What living creatures I had I loaded upon her.
I made go aboard all my family and kin,
Beasts of the steppe, wild animals of the steppe, all skilled craftsmen I made go on board.
Shamash set for me an appointed time:
"In the morning when it spates in cakes,
In the evening when it rains in grain,
Go into your ship, batten the door!"
That appointed time arrived,
In the morning spates in cakes,
In the evening rain in grain,
I gazed upon the appearance of the storm, the storm was frightful to behold!
I went into the ship and battened my door,
To the caulker of the ship, to Puzur-Amurri, the boatman,
I gave (away my) palace, with all its possessions.
At the first glimmer of dawn,
A black cloud rose up from the horizon,
Inside [the cloud] Adad was thundering ...

Adad's awesome power passed over the heavens,
Whatever was light he turned into darkness.
[He smote ...] the land, it shattered like a pot!
For one day the storm wind [],
Swiftly it blew, [the flood cam]e forth,

It was passing over the people like a battle.
No one could see his neighbor,
Nor could the people see each other in the downpour.
The gods became frightened of the deluge,
They shrank back and went up to Anu's highest heaven.
The gods cowered like dogs, crouching outside,
Ishtar screamed like a woman in childbirth,
And sweet-voiced Belet-[ili] moaned aloud:
"Would that day had turned to nought,
When I spoke up for evil in the assembly of the gods!
How could I have spoken up for evil in the assembly of the gods,
And spoken up for an assault to the death against my people?
It was I myself who bore my people!
(Now) like fish spawn they choke up the sea!"
The Anunna-gods were weeping with her,
The gods sat where they were (?), weeping.
Their lips were parched (?), taking on a crust.
Six days and [seven] nights
The wind continued, the deluge and windstorm leveled the land.
When the seventh day arrived, the windstorm and deluge left off their assault,
Which they had launched, like a fight to the death. The sea grew calm, the tempest grew still, the deluge
ceased.
I looked at the weather, stillness reigned,
And all of mankind had turned into clay.
The landscape was flat as a terrace.
I opened the hatch, daylight fell upon my face.
Crumpling over, I sat down and wept,
Tears running down my face.
I beheld the edges of the world, bordering the sea,
At twelve times sixty leagues a mountain rose up.
The boat rested on Mount Nimush,
Mount Nimush held the boat fast, not allowing it to move.
One day, a second day Mount Nimush held the boat fast, not allowing it to move.
A third day, a fourth day Mount Nimush held the boat fast, not allowing it to move.
A fifth day, a sixth day Mount Nimush held the boat fast, not allowing it to move.
When the seventh day arrived,
I released a dove to go free,
The dove went and returned,
No landing place came to view, it turned back.
I released a swallow to go free,
The swallow went and returned,
No landing place came to view, it turned back.
I sent a raven to go free,
The raven went forth, saw the ebbing of the waters,
It ate, circled, left droppings, did not turn back.
I released (all) to the four cardinal points,

I set up an offering stand on the top of the mountain.
 Seven and seven cult vessels I set out,
 I heaped reeds, cedar, and myrtle in their bowls.
 The gods smelled the savor,
 The gods smelled the sweet savor,
 The gods crowded around the sacrificer like flies.
 As soon as Belet-ili arrived,
 She held up the great fly-ornaments that Anu had made her in his infatuation,
 "O these gods here, as surely as I shall not forget this lapis on my neck,
 I shall be mindful of these days, and not forget, forever!
 Let the gods come to the offering,
 But Enlil must not come to the offering,
 For he, unreasoning, brought on the deluge,
 And reckoned my people for destruction!"
 Suddenly, as Enlil arrived,
 He saw the boat, Enlil became angry,
 He was filled with fury at the gods.
 "Who came out alive?"
 No man was to survive destruction!"
 Ninurta made ready to speak, and said to the warrior Enlil,
 "Who but Ea could devise such a thing?
 For Ea alone knows every craft."
 Ea made ready to speak, and said to the warrior Enlil,
 "You, O warrior, are the sage of the gods,
 How could you, unreasoning, have brought on the deluge?
 Impose punishment on the sinner for his sin, on the transgressor for his transgression,
 (But) be lenient, lest he be cut off, bear with him, lest he fall.
 Instead of your bringing on the flood, would a lion had risen up to diminish mankind!
 Instead of your bringing on the flood, would a wolf had risen up to diminish mankind!
 Instead of your bringing on the flood, would a famine had risen up for the land to undergo,
 Instead of your bringing on the flood, would pestilence had risen up for mankind to undergo!
 I was not the one who disclosed the secret of the great gods,
 I made Atra-hasis see a dream, he heard a secret of the gods.
 Now then, make some plan for him."
 Then Enlil came up into the ship,
 Leading me by the hand, he brought me up too.
 He took my wife up and made her kneel beside me,
 He touched our brows, stood between us and blessed us,
 "Hitherto Utnapishtim has been a human being,
 Now Utnapishtim and his wife shall become like us gods,
 Utnapishtim shall dwell afar-off at the source of the rivers."
 Thus it was they took me afar-off and made me dwell at the source of the rivers."

Hallo, William W. and Younger, K. Lawson (1997). [*The Context of Scripture, Volume 1: Canonical Compositions from the Biblical World*](#). Brill Academic Publishers.

The Atrahasis Epic

Atrahasis made ready to speak,
And said to his lord:
"Make me know the meaning [of the dream],
[] let me know, that I may look out for its consequence."
(15) [Enki] made ready to speak,
And said to his servant:
"You might say, 'Am I to be looking out while in the bedroom?'
Do you pay attention to message that I speak for you:
(20) 'Wall, listen to me!
Reed wall, pay attention to all my words!
Flee the house, build a boat,
Forsake possessions, and save life.
(25) The boat which you build,
[] be equal []

[gap]

Roof her over like the depth,
(30) So that the sun shall not see inside her,
Let her be roofed over fore and aft.
The gear should be very strong,
The pitch should be firm, and so give (the boat) strength.
I will shower down upon you later
(35) A windfall of birds, a spate (?) of fishes.'
He opened the water clock and filled it,
He told it of the coming of the seven-day deluge.
Atrahasis received the command,
He assembled the elders at his gate.
(40) Atrahasis made ready to speak,
And said to the elders:
"My god [does not agree] with your god,
Enki and [Enlil] are constantly angry with each other.
They have expelled me from [the land (?)].
(45) Since I have always revered [Enki],
[He told me] this.
I can[not] live in []
Nor can I [set my feet on] the earth of Enlil.
[I will dwell (?)] with god in (?) the depths."
(50) "[This] he told me [] ..."
[gap of four or five lines]

(ii 10) The elders []
The carpenter [carried his axe],
The reed-worker [carried his stone].

[The rich man? carried] the pitch,
The poor man [brought the materials needed].

[gap]

Bringing []

(ii 30) Whatever he [had]

Whatever he had []

Pure (animals) he sl[aughtered, cattle] ...

Fat (animals) [he killed, sheep (?)] ...

He chose and brought on] board.

(ii 35) The [birds] flying in the heavens,

The cattle (?) [and of the cat]tle god,

The [creatures (?)] of the steppe,

[] he brought on board

[]...

(ii 40) [] he invited his people

[] to a feast.

[] his family he brought on board.

While one was eating and another was drinking,

(ii 45) He went in and out; he could not sit, could not kneel,

For his heart was broken, he was retching gall.

The outlook of the weather changed,

Adad began to roar in the clouds.

(ii 50) The god they heard, his clamor.

He brought pitch to seal his door.

By the time he had bolted his door,

Adad was roaring in the clouds.

The winds were furious as he set forth,

(ii 55) He cut the mooring rope and released the boat.

[four lines lost]

(iii 5) [] the storm

[] were yoked

[Anzu rent] the sky with his talons,

[He] the land

(iii 10) And broke its clamor [like a pot].

[] the flood [came forth],

Its power came upon the peoples [like a battle].

One person did [not] see another,

They could [not] recognize each other in the catastrophe.

(iii 15) [The deluge] bellowed like a bull,

The wind [resound]ed like a screaming eagle.

The darkness [was dense], the sun was gone,

[] ... like flies

(iii 20) [the clamor (?)] of the deluge ...

Eridu Genesis

Language: Sumerian / Date: 17th century B.C.E.

And as Ziusudra stood there beside it, he [went on he]aring:

"Step up to the wall to my left and listen!

Let me speak a word to you at the wall

[and may you grasp] what [I] say,

May you he[ed] my advice!

By our hand a flood will sweep over

(the cities of) the half-bushel bas[kets, and the country;]

[the decision,] that mankind is to be destroyed,

has been made.

a verdict, a command of the assemb[ly

cannot be revoked,]

(100') an order of An and En[lil is not known

ever to have been countermanded,]

their kingship, their term, [has been uprooted

they must bethink themselves of that]

Now [...] What I ha[ve to say to you ..."] [...]

[Gap: Lost account of Enki's advice to build a boat and load it with pairs of living things and Ziusudra's compliance.]

All the evil winds, all stormy winds gathered into one and with them, then, the Flood was sweeping over (the cities of)

the half-bushel baskets

for seven days and seven nights.

After the flood had swept over the country,

after the evil wind had tossed the big boat about on the great waters,

the sun came out spreading light over heaven and earth.

Ziusudra then drilled an opening in the big boat.

and the gallant Utu sent his light

into the interior of the big boat.

(140') Ziusudra, being the king,

stepped up before Utu kissing the ground (before him).

The king was butchering oxen, was being lavish with the sheep

[barley cak]es, crescents together with [...]

[...] he was crumbling for him [...]

[juniper, the pure plant of the

mountains] he filled [on the fire]

and with a [...] clasped to

[the breast he ...] [...]